

Website launch: DNS and email safety checklist

For project managers: how to launch or move a client's website without breaking their email.

Before you touch DNS

- ☐ Find out who holds the registrar login and the DNS login. They are often different companies. Ask for your own delegated access instead of the owner's password, and confirm who will approve the MFA prompt on launch day.
- ☐ Record every existing record. Export the zone file or take screenshots: A, AAAA, CNAME, MX, TXT (SPF, DKIM, DMARC, verification codes) and SRV.
- ☐ Note where the client's email lives (the MX record tells you) and who their IT contact is.
- ☐ Lower the TTL on the records you will change, for example to 300 seconds, at least 24 to 48 hours ahead. Wait longer if the current TTL is longer.
- ☐ Change only the website records (A, AAAA or CNAME for the root and www). Avoid moving nameservers. If you must, recreate every record at the new DNS host first and compare line by line. Import tools miss records.
- ☐ Never delete or overwrite MX, SPF, DKIM or DMARC records when you move a website.
- ☐ A domain can have only one SPF record. Add new senders to the existing one. A second SPF record breaks both. SPF also stops working past 10 DNS lookups.

Website forms that send email

- ☐ Do not rely on the web server's built-in mail function. Send through an authenticated sending service or the client's own mail provider.
- ☐ Authorize that sender in the client's DNS before launch: add it to the SPF record and publish its DKIM keys. The From domain must match a domain that passes SPF or DKIM, or DMARC fails.
- ☐ Do not send "from" the client's domain through a sender that has not been authorized. It lands in junk or bounces, especially when the domain's DMARC policy is quarantine or reject.
- ☐ Never put the visitor's address in From. Use a real address at the client's domain and put the visitor in Reply-To.
- ☐ Send notifications to two people or a shared mailbox, and store form entries on the site as well.

After launch, the same day

- ☐ Email the client from an outside account and have them reply. Test both directions.
- ☐ Submit every form. Confirm it reaches the inbox, not junk, and that the message headers show SPF, DKIM and DMARC as "pass".
- ☐ Check SPF and DMARC with the free checker at supremeitexperts.com/check. It reads public MX, SPF and DMARC records. No sign-up.
- ☐ Check www and non-www, the HTTPS certificate, and any subdomains (portal, remote, autodiscover).
- ☐ After a few quiet days, raise the TTLs again.

Rollback plan (write it before launch)

- ☐ Keep the old site and hosting live for a week or two. With low TTLs, rollback means putting the old values back from your export.
- ☐ Decide in advance who makes the call, and when. For example: "If email is not flowing 30 minutes after the change, we roll back."
- ☐ If email breaks, compare the live MX and TXT records with your export, restore what is missing, and tell the client right away.

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